

Threat Modeling Model Creation Procedure

Revision

Version 9
4/27/26 6:34 PM

SME

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Abstract

This document describes the procedure used to perform the threat model creation activity described in the AVCDL secondary document **Threat Modeling Report** ^[2].

Group / Owner

Security / Security Architect

Motivation

This document is motivated by the need to identify design deficiencies related to cybersecurity as early in the product development process as possible. This is necessary given the nature of safety-critical, cyber-physical systems.

Note: Within the context of this document, the terms ***security*** and ***cybersecurity*** are used interchangeably. It is presumed that the term ***security*** is being used in reference to ***cybersecurity*** and not ***physical security***.

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Audience

The audience of this document is the cybersecurity practitioner who will be conducting the cybersecurity threat model creation.

Completeness of Output

Since threat modeling is an as-is analysis, it is critical to ensure that the information gathered is as accurate and complete as possible. As with any cybersecurity assessment, it is not the place of the cybersecurity SME to make assumptions on the part of engineering. All information should be sourced from and confirmed by the owner of the element under consideration.

When information is not available for either a given section of the template or parts thereof, this should be noted. Major omissions should be recorded in the cybersecurity risk register.

Disposition of Output

Once completed, the generated output should be managed in the organization's document management system (DMS) as a document of record.

Entry Criteria

This document assumes that the reader understands the purpose of cybersecurity threat modeling. Further, that the reader has read and understood the AVCDL **Threat Modeling Report** secondary document.

Prerequisites – Development SME

Qualifications

It is required that the development SME is both a qualified and trained development SME with expertise in the element under consideration.

Note: The specific qualifications and training of development SMEs necessary to assert expertise in providing accurate information regarding the element under consideration is outside the scope of this document.

Note: The development group is responsible for determining and making available the appropriate SME for the analysis of the element under consideration.

Knowledge

It is required that the development SME have expertise in the element under consideration.

Prerequisites – Threat Modeling SME

Qualifications

It is required that the threat modeling SME is both a qualified and trained security architect (shown above on title page as **Owner**) as defined by the **NIST NCWF** role SP-ARC-002 and detailed in the **NCWF Roles - Security Architect** section of the **AVCDL Background Material** elaboration document [\[10\]](#).

Knowledge

It is required that the threat modeling SME understands the purpose of cybersecurity threat modeling.

Background Information

It is required that the threat modeling SME has read and understands the AVCDL **Attack Surface Analysis Report** [\[6\]](#), **Threat Modeling Report**, and **Security Requirements Taxonomy** [\[3\]](#) secondary documents. Additionally, that the cybersecurity SME has taken training relevant to this activity.

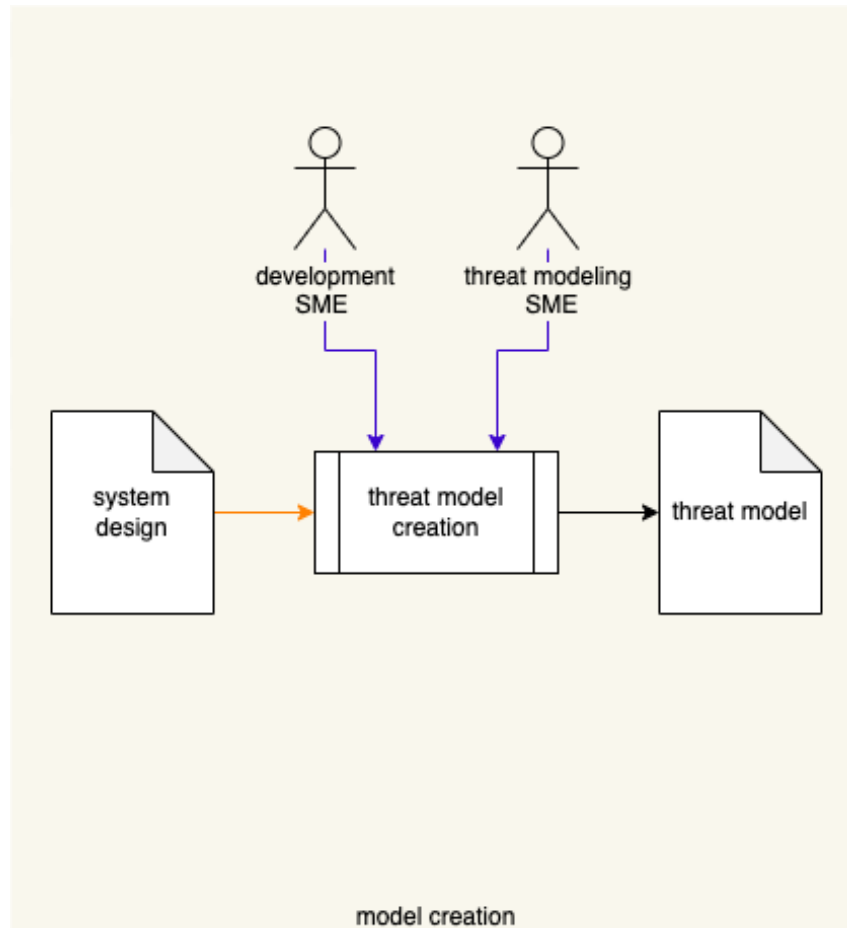
Prerequisites – Input Materials

It is required that the development group provide all relevant documentation related to the element under consideration necessary to complete the procedure.

Note: Because the scope of threat modeling is variable, the specific documentation required will be determined and provided to the development group by the threat modeling SME prior to the start of the element's model creation.

Model Creation Activity

The workflow diagram for the model creation activity of the **Threat Modeling Report** is shown below.

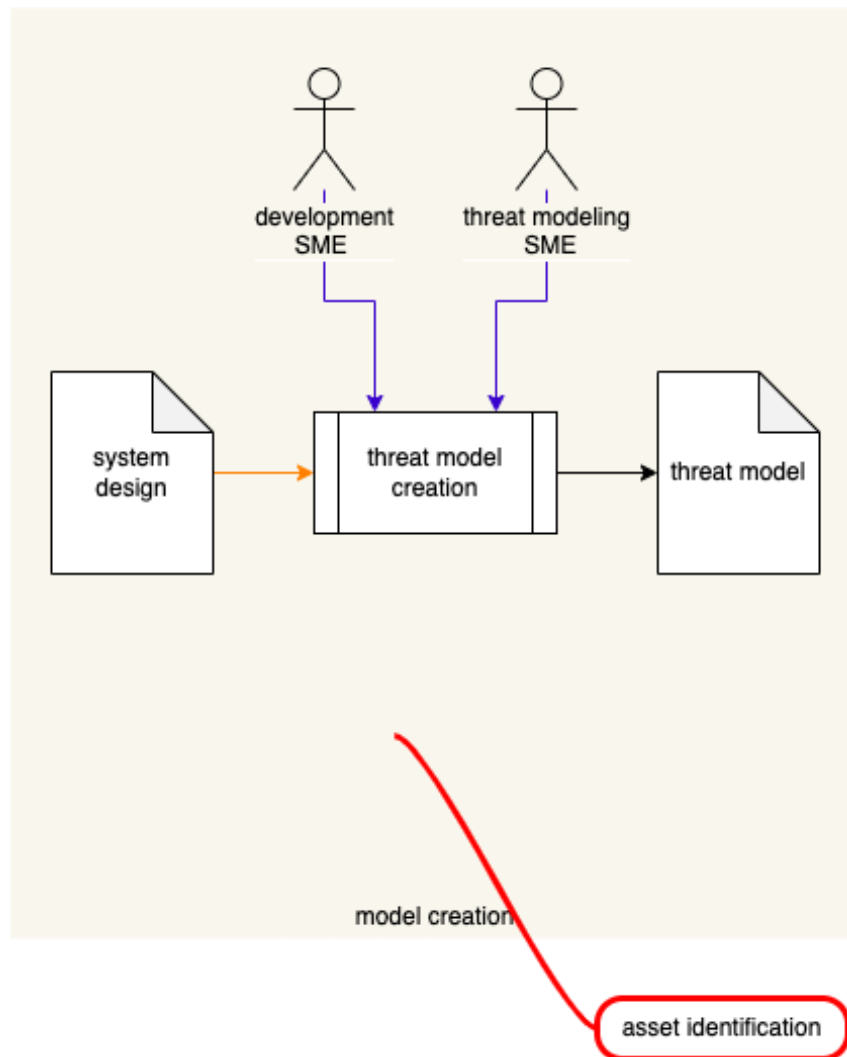


Using the **system design**, the threat modeling SME works with the development SME(s) to create a model of the system suitable for threat analysis. Any existing models are used as input to this process. For this activity, models are created using a formal modeling tool when feasible. This may be a set of models depending on the complexity of the system. A **threat model** is created. The model is stored in the DMS.

Note: The **system design** may include information attained from attack surface analysis activities.

Theory

The AVCDL **Understanding TARA in an AVCDL Context** ^[5] elaboration document notes that the **model creation** activity equates to the **asset identification** activity of various standards. This is shown in the following diagram. This is the fundamental task of model creation.



Scope

When performing threat model creation, it is essential to limit the scope of the element under consideration. The goal of the threat modeling exercise is to establish that appropriate controls are in place to ensure the cybersecurity posture of the element, not other elements which connect to it. When properly created, the threat models of multiple interacting elements will require no modification if composed into a larger abstraction.

Note: There is a very strong temptation to try and consider the other elements when threat modeling. Doing so will only waste time as the development SME is providing information only for the element under consideration. Additionally, other elements will be subject to threat models of their own.

Note: There is also a very strong temptation to try fit everything conceivable into the element scope. This will result in either an incomplete model or an overly complicated one.

Goal

The goal of threat modeling is the establishment of a set of controls necessary to ensure that data crossing a threat boundary can do so securely. Threat modeling cannot assess whether behaviors within a process are correct.

Data Flow Diagram Entities

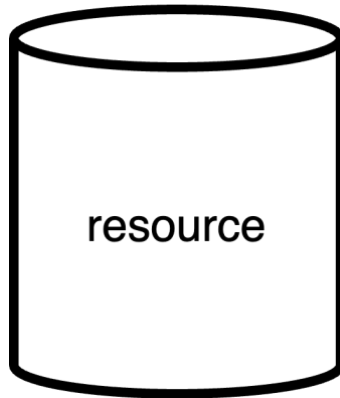
The AVCDL video **Cybersecurity Requirements-based Threat Modeling** ^[7] describes the creation of a data flow diagram (DFD) from the block view of a system and shows how that decomposition changes based on the level of abstraction. There are five entity types used within the DFD. These are **resources**, **processes**, **interactors**, **boundaries**, and **data flows**.

Note: The combination of a **resource** and its associated owning **process** separated from other processes by a **boundary**, constitute an asset.

Note: With the exception of boundaries, entity instance names should be unique. In the case of data flows the name should be of the form **<source> to <destination>**. This is so that issues can be unambiguously identified.

Resources

In their simplest form, resources are data stores. They are represented diagrammatically by cylinders as shown below.

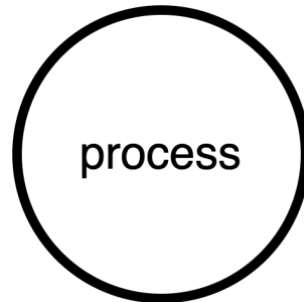


Resources have the following attributes:

- Has unique ID
- Is read-only
- Is structured
- Contains PII
- Contains credentials
- Is encrypted
- Is integrity checked
- Data type
 - Analog
 - Executable
 - Configuration data
 - Data log
 - Audit log

Processes

Processes are responsible for management of resources. They are represented diagrammatically by circles as shown below.



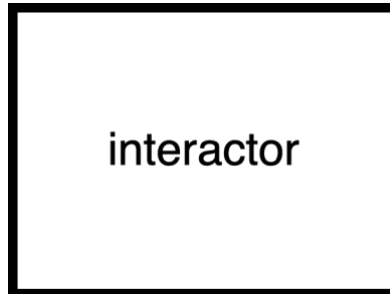
Processes have the following attributes:

- Has unique ID
- Is authenticated
- Is authorized
- Type
 - Driver
 - Service
 - Process
- Class
 - OS
 - Third-party
 - Self
 - External

Note: In **DFD3** ^[9], the process entity is represented using a rounded rectangle. The choice of symbol in this instance should be made in order to communicate consistently.

Interactors

Interactors are non-process entities external to the element. They are represented diagrammatically by rectangles as shown below.



Interactors have the following attributes:

- Type
 - Person
 - Analog

Trust Boundaries

Trust boundaries are used to denote a specific region of trust. They are represented diagrammatically by dashed arcs as shown below.

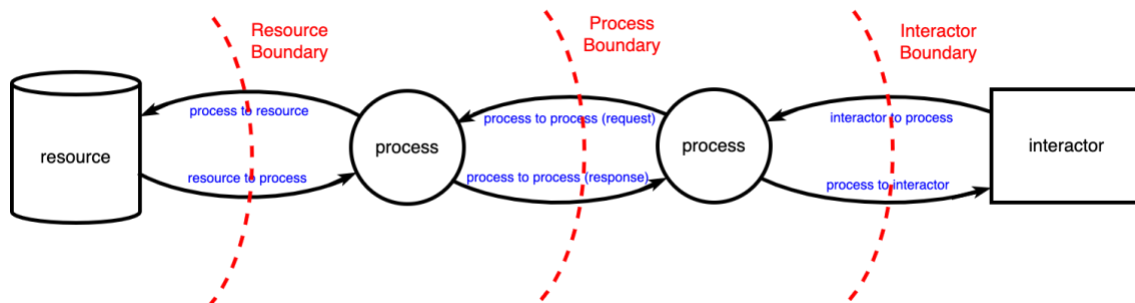


Boundaries have the following attributes:

- Type
 - Machine
 - Network
 - Interprocess
 - OS
 - Resource
 - External interactor

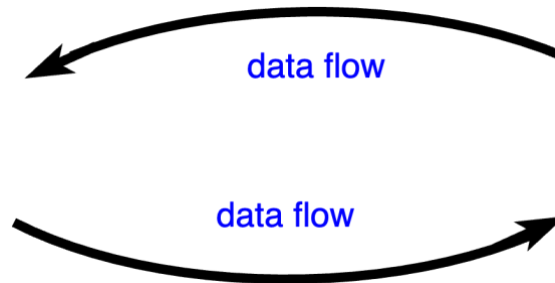
Note: Abstractions such as hypervisors would use **machine** boundaries.

Note: For emphasis, boundaries are drawn with the convex side toward the element being modeled. The resultant diagram emphasizes the element having a series of boundary shells. This is illustrated in the following diagram where the resource is the focus of protection.



Data Flows

Data flows are used to denote any data passing from one non-boundary entity to another. They are represented diagrammatically by solid arcs with an arrow indicating the destination of the data flow, as shown below.



Data flows have the following attributes:

- Requires acknowledgement
- Has sequence numbers
- Has authenticated source
- Has authenticated destination
- Is safety-critical
- Integrity check
 - None
 - Simple (CRC)
 - Cryptographic
- Encryption
 - None
 - Symmetric
 - Asymmetric

Note: Double-ended arced arrows are not used as they imply symmetries which are not necessarily true. Always show each data flow separately. Additionally, analysis is not performed on outbound data flows as they do not impact the cybersecurity of the element under consideration.

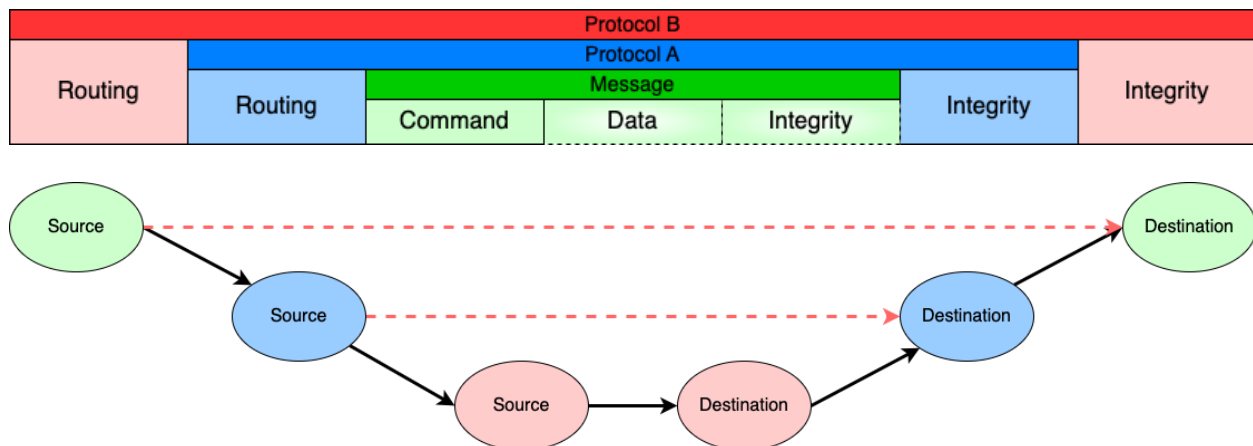
Methodology

Resolution Determination

The first step in creation of the threat model is the determination of the model's resolution.

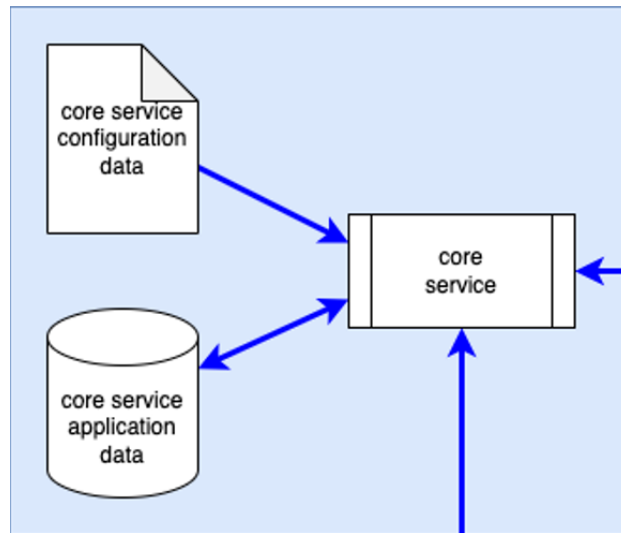
Note: It is not the goal of the threat model creation activity to produce a single all-encompassing diagram of the system. It is expected that there will be a number of diagrams necessary to cover the model. The exact number will depend upon the complexity of the element's scope.

To appreciate why multiple diagrams are necessary, consider the following diagram from the AVCDL **Cybersecurity Requirements Taxonomy** ^[8] video.

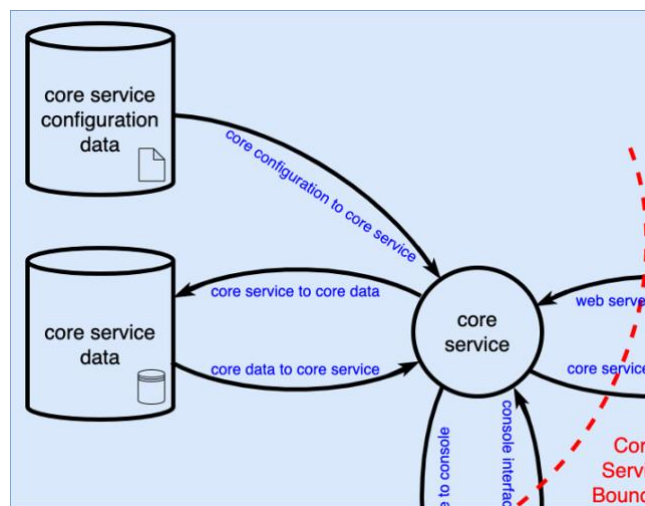


Here we have a message with multiple intermediaries between the intended source and destination. This is a fairly typical situation. If the model covers the dataflows shown in black, but excludes those in red (dashed), certain types of cybersecurity design flaws will be overlooked.

Consider the following concrete example of a simple system with a core service providing information to the larger system.



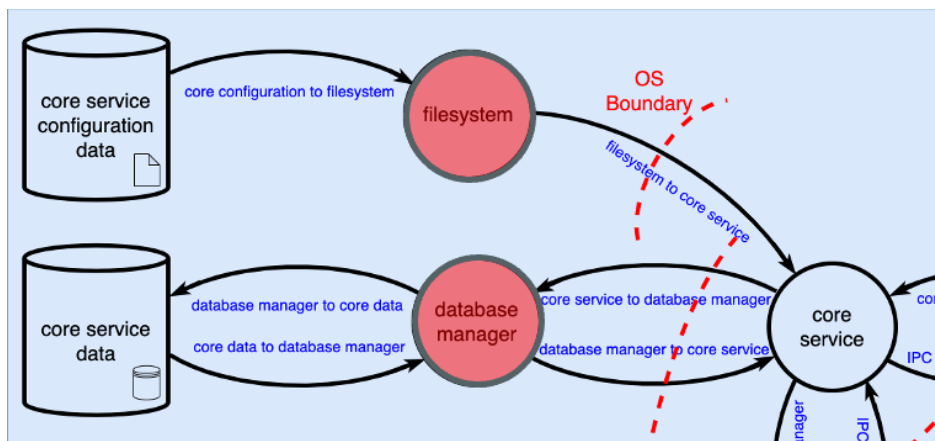
We can see that the core service process uses a read-only configuration file and read-write application data file. If we create a DFD directly from this diagram, we get the following:



The translation to a DFD is fairly straightforward.

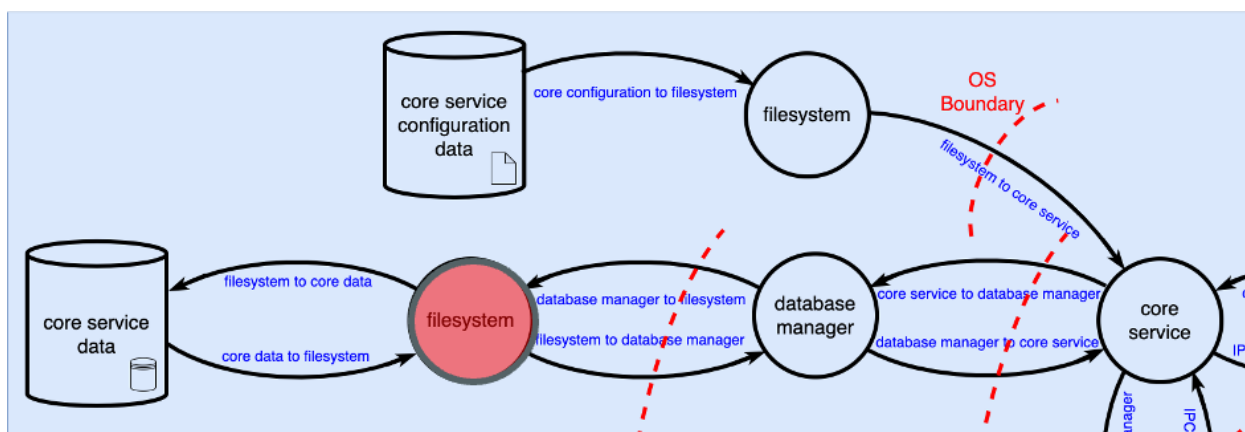
Note: The resources have been annotated to indicate the distinction between structured and unstructured data.

There is, however, a level of abstraction not being represented. The following exposes this level.



The **core service** accesses the **configuration data** and **application data** via the **filesystem** and **database manager** services (shown in red). Additional trust boundaries are now evident.

But even this representation hides information. The following diagram reveals one additional level of abstraction.



Here we see the intermediation between the **database manager** and the file holding the database.

Resource Ownership

When constructing the element model, it is important to ensure that every resource has one owning (managing) process. As seen about in the discussion of DFD levels, the **core service data** is managed by only a single process regardless of the level. One can consider that ownership is delegated as the level increases.

Note: Resources with multiple owners indicate a fundamental flaw in the element's design.

Operating System Abstraction

One of the most overlooked abstractions is that of the operating system. The cybersecurity controls that can be applied to an element are constrained by the sophistication of the operating system.

Consider the following operating system decomposition by scale.

OS feature support 				
	tiny	small	medium	large
common name	bare metal	embedded	RTOS	PC
examples	N/A	FileX NetX ThreadX QPano	AUTOSAR QNX VxWorks	MacOS Linux Windows
linkage	N/A	static	dynamic	dynamic
thread model	N/A	cooperative	preemptive	preemptive
user levels	N/A	none	user / system	ACL-based
isolation	N/A	none	minimal	full

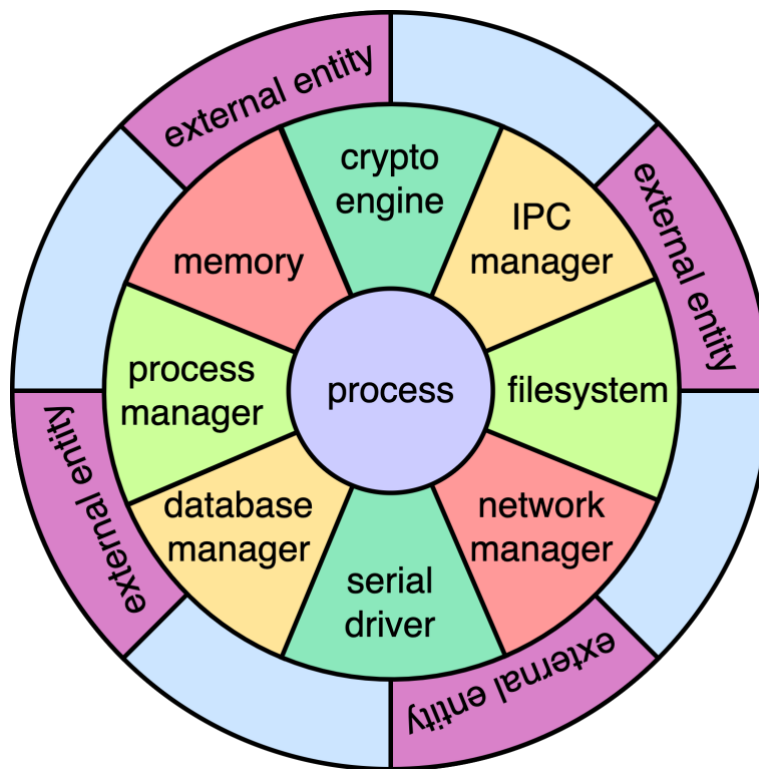
As we move from **tiny** to **large** scale, more cybersecurity controls become useable. At the same time, there are many more processes and trust boundaries to account for.

Fundamentally, the operating system provides four core processes. These are:

- Filesystem
- Process manager
- Interprocess communications (IPC) manager
- Network manager

Depending upon the scale of the operating system, one or more of these may be absent.

In medium and large scale operating systems, a number of other processes (managers) are provided. If we think about the element from the point of view of an individual process within the element, we have the following arrangement.



This view makes it clear where trust boundaries exist.

Note: In this view, a resource is treated like any other external entity (managed by some operating system process).

Open Source / Third-Party Abstraction

Both open source and third-party processes should be treated the same as operating systems ones.

Note: It is just as important to understand the trust relationships between the element and any open source or third-party processes as it is to do so with the operating system processes.

DFD Creation

Since attempting to perform threat modeling using a single DFD representing all possible data flows for all workflows is infeasible, a set of DFDs must be created. These allow for the ease of analysis and issue tracking.

Element-only DFD

This first DFD created focuses only on those entities within the element owned by the organization and the external entities with which they interact.

Note: This view will not be used in the threat modeling activity. It serves as a reference to anchor the element's workflow DFDs.

Non-element Process DFDs

Because the non-element processes (operating system, third-party, and open source) are not monolithic, a DFD should be created for each. This allows specific cybersecurity controls to be assessed without distracting from the element's workflows.

Workflow DFDs

The workflow-level DFDs are limited in scope to a single operational activity. This both allows for easy addition of new workflows and also simplifies analysis (and by extension mitigation).

Note: It is understood that as the complexity of the element increases, so does the number of workflow DFDs required to fully describe the element.

Threat Model Template

The element cybersecurity requirements catalog may be documented using the **AVCDL threat modeling model template** Microsoft Excel workbook [\[4\]](#).

Note: Other forms of documentation are permissible so long as they provide the information laid out in this document.

There are eleven sheets in the workbook. They are:

- [Cover sheet](#)
- [Revision history](#)
- [Reference documents](#)
- [Diagrams](#)
- [DFDs](#)
- [Resource entities](#)
- [Process entities](#)
- [Interactor entities](#)
- [Boundary entities](#)
- [Data flow entities](#)
- [Legend](#)

These will be addressed in turn.

Duplication of Rows in the Various Sheets

When there is the need to add rows to the various sheets of the workbook, be sure to duplicate an existing row. This is because validation checks are attached to some of the cells which also enables the use of dropdown lists.

Cover Sheet

The **cover sheet** of the workbook is shown below:

Threat Modeling - Model								
Element Name	Element Name							
Element Scope	Element Scope							
Vendor Name	Vendor Name							
Threat Modeling SME	Threat Modeling SME							
Development SME	Development SME							
Date	27-Aug-2000							
Model Revision	1							

Fields to be completed are shown in **red**.

Element Name

The **element name** is the element being modeled.

Element Scope

The scope of the element is left to the discretion of the customer. Examples of element scopes include system, sub-system, component, component software (non-OS), and component OS.

Note: In this context, **the customer** refers to the entity requiring the activity.

Vendor Name

This is the name of the vendor responsible for the element being modeled.

Threat Modeling SME

This is the threat modeling subject matter expert creating the threat model.

Development SME

This is the development subject matter expert providing element information for the creation of the threat model.

Date

This is the date when the element's threat model was created or updated. The date should be updated whenever the model is updated.

Revision

This is the revision number of the document. The revision number is a monotonic and increasing integer, starting at 1. It should be incremented every time the document is updated.

Revision History

The **revision history** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Revision History		
Revision	Author	Description
1		initial revision

Revision

The **revision** corresponds to that listed on the cover sheet.

Author

The **author** corresponds to the threat modeling SME listed on the cover sheet.

Description

This is a brief description of changes made to the threat model since it was last updated.

Reference Documents

Note: These references are those necessary for the creation of the element's threat model.

The **references** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Reference Documents		
Name	Description	Location

Name

This is the name of the document being referenced.

Description

This is a brief description of the document being referenced.

Location

This is the location of the document being referenced. It may be a physical location or a URL.

Diagrams

The **diagrams** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Element Diagrams								
insert diagrams with description here								

Element diagrams are inserted images with attendant explanations. The intent of these diagrams is to provide a mechanism for establishing the various entities necessary for the creation of an accurate threat model. These diagrams show the various relationships between various features of the element, a context which lists alone cannot provide.

The utility of the element model diagram is that it aides in the collection of the threat model inputs. In practice, each of these features should be uniquely enumerated to clearly document issues identified in the analysis.

The unique identifiers (names) of the various parts of the diagram should correspond to those used in the other sections of the threat modeling analysis workbook.

There are many possibilities for the diagrams included. These range from annotated photographs or CAD drawings in the case of physical elements, block diagrams which are useful at the system level, and DFDs for purely software scope elements.

The requirement for this section is that at least one visualization that appropriately conveys the structure of the element be included.

DFDs

The **DFDs** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Threat Model DFDs								
insert DFDs with description here								

Threat model DFDs are inserted images with attendant explanations. These diagrams provide a visualization of the information contained in the following sheets.

The utility of these diagrams is that they allow for the threat modeling SME performing the threat model analysis to provide workflow-specific DFDs showing only necessary entities.

Note: For ease of use by the threat modeling SME responsible for analyzing the model, it is recommended to replicate the **DFDs** sheet and add a suffix to the name.

Resource Entities

The **resource entities** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Resource Entities											
ID	name	description	has unique ID	is read-only	is structured	contains PII	contains credentials	is encrypted	is integrity checked	resource type	notes

ID

This is the unique threat model ID of the resource.

Name

This is the name of the resource.

Description

This is the description of the resource.

Has Unique ID

This indicates whether the resource has a unique identifier within the context of the element.

Is Read-only

This indicates whether the resource is read-only.

Is Structured

This indicates whether the resource storage is structured (database). This determines whether there is an intermediating process needed to manage it (DBMS).

Contains PII

This indicates whether the resource contains PII data.

Contains Credentials

This indicates whether the resource contains credential data.

Is Encrypted

This indicates whether the resource is encrypted.

Is Integrity Checked

This indicates whether the resource provides data integrity checking.

Resource Type

This is the type of data stored in the resource. The type may be one of the following:

- generic
- analog
- executable
- configuration data
- data log
- audit log

Notes

This is a general notes field.

Process Entities

The **process entities** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Process Entities								
ID	name	description	has unique ID	is authenticated	is authorized	process type	process class	notes

ID

This is the unique threat model ID of the process.

Name

This is the name of the process.

Description

This is the description of the process.

Has Unique ID

This indicates whether the process has a unique identifier within the context of the element.

Is Authenticated

This indicates whether the process is authenticated before use.

Is Authorized

This indicates whether the process is authorized for the operations it carries out.

Process Type

This is the type of the process. The type may be one of the following:

- process
- driver
- service / daemon

Process Class

This is the owner of the process. The class of the process carries both trust and ownership implications. The type may be one of the following:

- OS
- Third-party
- Self
- External

Note: **Third-party** encompasses all processes which are neither OS nor self in ownership within the scope of the element. Open source software processes are included in this.

Note: **External** encompasses all processes which are outside of the scope of the element.

Notes

This is a general notes field.

Interactor Entities

The **interactor entities** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Interactor Entities				
ID	name	description	interactor type	notes

ID

This is the unique threat model ID of the interactor.

Name

This is the name of the interactor.

Description

This is the description of the interactor.

Interactor Type

This is the type of the interactor. The type may be one of the following:

- Person
- Analog

Notes

This is a general notes field.

Boundary Entities

The **boundary entities** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Boundary Entities				
ID	name	description	boundary type	notes

ID

This is the unique threat model ID of the boundary.

Name

This is the name of the boundary.

Description

This is the description of the boundary.

Boundary Type

This is the type of the boundary with respect to the element. The type may be one of the following:

- Interprocess
- Machine
- Network
- OS
- Resource
- External Interactor

Notes

This is a general notes field.

Data Flow Entities

The **data flow entities** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

Data Flow Entities													
ID	name	protocol	description	source ID	destination ID	requires acknowledgement	has sequence numbers	has authenticated source	has authenticated destination	is safety-critical	integrity check	encryption	notes

ID

This is the unique threat model ID of the data flow.

Name

This is the name of the data flow.

Note: It is recommended that the name be of the form **<source> to <destination>**.

Protocol

This is the name of the protocol used by the data flow.

Description

This is the description of the data flow.

Source ID

This is the unique threat model ID of the source of the data flow.

Destination ID

This is the unique threat model ID of the destination of the data flow.

Requires Acknowledgement

This indicates whether the data flow's protocol requires acknowledgement of receipt of the data.

Has Sequence Numbers

This indicates whether the data flow's protocol contains sequence numbers.

Has Authenticated Source

This indicates whether the data flow's protocol has source authentication.

Has Authenticated Destination

This indicates whether the data flow's protocol has destination authentication.

Is Safety-critical

This indicates whether the data flow is safety-critical in nature.

Integrity Check

This indicates the data flow protocol's data integrity checking mechanism. This may be one of the following:

- None
- Simple (CRC)
- Cryptographic

Encryption

This indicates the data flow protocol's encryption mechanism. This may be one of the following:

- None
- Symmetric
- Asymmetric

Notes

This is a general notes field.

Legend

The **legend** sheet of the workbook is shown below:

resource type	bool	process class	process type	interactor type	boundary type	intergrity check	encryption
generic	no	OS	process	person	interprocess	none	none
analog	yes	third-party	driver	analog	machine	simple (CRC)	symmetric
executable		self	service/daemon		network	cryptographic	asymmetric
configuration data		external			OS		
data log					resource		
audit log					external interactor		

The **legend** sheet information is used to make the completion of the document easier by providing dropdown lists for common values. It also ensures that spelling errors do not creep into the generated material.

Note: The legend sheet should not be edited. If an unlisted value is required, the template should be separately revised.

Exit Criteria

This procedure is considered complete once the generated output has been entered into the organization's DMS as a document of record.

Note: The processes and procedures for entering documents into the DMS, or the updating thereof, are outside the scope of this document.

References

1. **AVCDL** (AVCDL primary document)
2. **Threat Modeling Report** (AVCDL secondary document)
3. **Security Requirements Taxonomy** (AVCDL secondary document)
4. **AVCDL threat modeling model template** (AVCDL template)
5. **Understanding TARA in an AVCDL Context** (AVCDL elaboration document)
6. **Attack Surface Analysis Report** (AVCDL secondary document)
7. **Cybersecurity Requirements-based Threat Modeling** (AVCDL video)
8. **Cybersecurity Requirements Taxonomy** (AVCDL video)
9. **DFD3**
<https://github.com/adamshostack/DFD3>
10. **AVCDL Background Material** (AVCDL elaboration document)